

THE ART OF ACTING: CRAFT, CALLING, AND CONSECRATION

A key note lecture delivered on the occasion of X-theatre (drama) ministers' retreat of The Rest Place, Church of God Mission International (CGMi)

Lecture prepared and delivered

by:

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Date: 25th July. 2026

Venue: The Rest Place, CGMi, KDC Hall, 202a Aba Road, Waterlines, Port Harcourt.

Time: 9:00am – 2:00pm

Introduction: Acting as an Art and an Altar

Good day, brethren, ministers, and fellow artists. When we hear the phrase “The Art of Acting,” our minds immediately travel to technique. We think of voice projection that fills a hall without a microphone. We think of character analysis, motivation, objectives, and obstacles. We think of stage presence, blocking, timing, and emotional truth. In the secular academy, theatre is treated as a discipline to be mastered through years of study and practice. But in the context of Christian ministry, acting must rise beyond technique. It must become consecrated craft. The stage becomes an altar. The actor becomes a priest. The performance becomes an offering. We are not here to entertain for vanity. We are here to steward gifts. We are here to tell stories that reflect truth, expose the human condition, and ultimately point men to divine grace. If we miss this, we reduce sacred work to mere show business. If we embrace it, we discover that acting is both art and altar.

Biblical Foundation for Stewardship

The Bible is clear about gifts. 1 Peter 4:10 says, “As each has received a gift, use it to serve one another, as good stewards of God’s varied grace.” Notice two words: gift and stewardship. Your talent is the gift. God sovereignly places it in you. Your technique is the stewardship. That is your responsibility. God gives the raw material — the voice, the body, the imagination, the sensitivity. But He expects us to refine it. In the parable of the talents, the master did not praise the servant who buried his talent. He praised the ones who worked it, multiplied it, and returned it with increase. Acting talent buried under laziness, pride, or “waiting for anointing” is still burial. We must rehearse. We must study. We must train. Because when we stand before an audience, we are not just representing ourselves. We are representing the God who gave us the gift. Stewardship demands excellence, preparation, and accountability.

The Danger of Extremes: Anointing vs Artistry

In Christian circles we often swing to extremes. One extreme says, “We don’t need training. Just the Holy Ghost.” The other says, “We don’t need the Spirit. Just good acting.” Both are dangerous. Theatre ministry is not “spirit-coco” alone. You cannot walk on stage with no blocking, no voice work, no character study, and expect the Spirit to do what discipline should have done. That is presumption. But you can also have perfect diction, perfect movement, and a dead spirit. That is performance without power. Anointing without skill leads to sloppy ministry that embarrasses the Gospel. Skill without the Spirit leads to hollow entertainment that moves emotions but not hearts. The truth is both hands washing each other. The Spirit empowers the craft. The craft gives the Spirit a worthy vessel. Jesus was full of the Spirit and full of wisdom. Paul was anointed and was also a trained rhetorician. We must pursue both.

Pillar 1: Truthfulness in Portrayal

The foundation of modern acting theory, from Konstantin Stanislavski to Sanford Meisner, is one idea: living truthfully under imaginary circumstances. The audience must believe you before they will believe your message. In ministry drama, this is even more critical. If we portray sin in a cartoonish way, people will not see themselves. If we portray repentance with exaggerated crying and falling, people will disengage. If we portray redemption as a magic trick, people will leave unchanged. Truthfulness means doing the research. What does addiction really look like? What does grief really sound like? What does conviction really feel like? We must live the character from the inside out. Not “act” the pastor, but become a man wrestling with calling. Not “act” the prostitute, but become a woman with wounds and choices. When truth is on stage, the Holy Spirit has something to anoint. When there is only performance, the Spirit has nothing to bless.

Pillar 2: Voice, Body, and Presence

God gave you a body as a physical stage and a voice as a trumpet. Isaiah 58:1 — “Lift up your voice like a trumpet.” In theatre, there is no rewind button. If the last row cannot hear you, your sermon is lost. Vocal clarity is therefore a spiritual responsibility. We must train breath support, articulation, resonance, and projection. The body is equally important. Every step, every gesture, every facial expression is communicating. Physical economy means no wasted movement. Unnecessary pacing, fidgeting, or “pussy-footing” distracts from the message. Your presence must command attention without demanding it. This is not pride. This is stewardship. David danced with all his might before the Lord. That was a physical offering. When we bring a disciplined body and a trained voice to God, our performance itself becomes worship. The medium becomes sacred.

Pillar 3: Empathy and Character Study

Acting requires the terrifying and beautiful act of stepping into someone else’s shoes. Sometimes those shoes belong to heroes of faith. Sometimes they belong to villains, backsliders, hypocrites, and broken people. To play them truthfully, you cannot judge them from the outside. You must seek to understand their motives, their wounds, their logic. Why did Judas betray? Why did Peter deny? Why does the young man choose fraud? This builds empathy. And empathy is not compromise. It is Christlikeness. Jesus wept with those who wept. He ate with

sinner not to endorse sin, but to understand and redeem. As actors and ministers, empathy allows us to portray humanity without condemnation, so that the audience sees themselves and sees a way out. Without empathy, our drama becomes moral lectures. With empathy, our drama becomes ministry.

Major Theories of Acting We Must Know

We cannot be ignorant of the tools of our trade. **Stanislavski's System** teaches us objectives, actions, and the "magic if." It asks, "What would I do if I were in this situation?" **Meisner Technique** teaches us to live truthfully in the moment and to react honestly to our scene partner. **Brechtian Epic Theatre** teaches us to create distance so the audience can think critically and not just feel. **Grotowski's Poor Theatre** strips away spectacle and says the actor-audience relationship is the core. **Uta Hagen** teaches substitution and truth. We do not adopt these theories wholesale. We baptize them. We filter them through Scripture. But to ignore them is to go to war unarmed. A minister who knows theology but not hermeneutics will misquote the Bible. In the same way, a drama minister who knows the anointing but not craft will misrepresent the truth.

Why Theory Matters in Ministry

Some people say, "Theory is for the university. We are for the church." That is a false divide. Theory is simply tested wisdom about how human beings behave, communicate, and change. When we understand objectives, we can make our characters purposeful instead of random. When we understand beats, we can structure a scene so it builds to a Gospel point. When we understand subtext, we can say one thing and mean another, just like Jesus in parables. Theory gives us precision. And precision honors God. God is a God of order, not confusion. When we are vague on stage, the message is vague in the heart. When we are specific, the Spirit can be specific in conviction. Ignorance of craft limits the reach of anointing. But knowledge submitted to the Spirit multiplies impact.

Drama as a Ministerial Tool

Why drama? Why not just preach? Because stories bypass human defenses. The human heart is guarded against direct confrontation. But a story slips past the gate. In 2 Samuel 12, Nathan did not begin with, "David, you are an adulterer and murderer." He told a story about a rich man and a poor man's ewe lamb. David's heart was moved to judgment before he realized the story was about him. That is the power of drama. Drama mirrors life. It holds up a mirror and says, "This is you." It pierces the heart without bruising the ego. It leads to self-realization. And self-realization is the doorway to repentance. Drama also heals. When people see their pain named on stage, they feel less alone. When they see a way forward dramatized, they receive hope. This is why Jesus taught in parables. He was the greatest drama minister.

Relevance in the Contemporary Body of Christ

The Church today is in competition for attention. Our members watch Netflix, TikTok, Nollywood, and YouTube for 4 hours a day. Then they come to church for 1 hour. If our drama is 20 minutes of shouting, dancing without purpose, and songs in the wrong key, we are losing them. But people still hunger for meaning. They hunger for stories that make sense of suffering,

injustice, and redemption. Christian drama can meet that hunger — but only if it is excellent. Mediocre drama pushes people away from the Church. It confirms the stereotype that “Christian things are not professional.” Excellent drama draws people to Christ because it respects them. In an age of distraction, excellence is evangelism. In an age of noise, truth told well is prophetic.

Relevance to Society at Large

Theatre has always been the conscience of society. From the Greek tragedies to Wole Soyinka, theatre holds a mirror to the nation. It asks hard questions. It exposes corruption. It laments injustice. It celebrates virtue. When the Church abandons this space, the world fills it with its own narratives — often destructive ones. If we are not telling stories about marriage, money, leadership, and integrity, Nollywood will. If we are not dramatizing the cost of fraud, the pain of broken homes, or the beauty of forgiveness, secular media will, and they will do it without hope. We must reclaim storytelling as a prophetic act. Not to copy the world, but to redeem the form. To show that the Gospel speaks to every area of life, not just Sunday.

Avenue 1: Preaching Without Preachiness

A sound Christian drama should not hammer the audience over the head with doctrine. People are tired of being shouted at. What they need is to see truth. Good drama illustrates the human experience so clearly that the truth becomes self-evident. The audience concludes what the sermon would have told them, but they conclude it themselves. That is more powerful. Doctrine is important, but people need to see doctrine embodied. Show me a man choosing forgiveness instead of telling me about forgiveness. Show me a woman choosing purity under pressure instead of preaching purity. When truth is enfleshed, it is more convincing than when it is only announced.

Avenue 2: Service to Humanity – Mirroring Reality

Theatre serves society by holding a mirror to its wounds. When a widow sees her grief portrayed with dignity, she feels seen. When a teenager sees the trap of internet fraud dramatized, he is warned. When a couple sees communication breakdown acted out, they are convicted. This is service. Jesus spent most of His ministry meeting people at the point of their need. Drama allows us to do the same at scale. We can take the pain of a community and put it on stage, not to shame, but to heal. We can show injustice, not to incite violence, but to call for repentance. When an audience sees their reality reflected with compassion and with a path to redemption, the door to the heart opens.

Avenue 3: Service to God – Excellence as Worship

In the Old Testament, God rejected blemished sacrifices. He said, “Bring your best.” That principle has not changed. Offering God half-hearted, unprepared, last-minute drama is a blemished offering. Excellence is not pride. Excellence is worship. When we memorize our lines, it is worship. When we block a scene 10 times, it is worship. When we design a set with care, it is worship. When we arrive early for rehearsal, it is worship. Colossians 3:23 — “Whatever you do, do it unto the Lord.” Our performance itself can be a liturgy. When technique and Spirit meet, the audience does not just applaud. They encounter God.

Expectations of the Church from Drama Ministers

The Church has the right to expect three things from us. **First, Integrity.** Live what you perform. You cannot preach holiness on stage and live in compromise off stage. The anointing and the lifestyle must match. **Second, Excellence.** Come prepared. Know your lines. Respect rehearsal times. Treat props and costumes with care. Stop treating ministry as casual. **Third, Discernment.** Choose stories that edify, not just entertain. Not every trending topic deserves a skit. Ask: Does this glorify God? Does this build the Church? Does this reflect biblical truth? We are not comedians for hire. We are custodians of sacred narrative. The pulpit is holy. So is the stage.

Expectations of Society from Christian Theatre

Society is also watching us. And they expect three things. **Relevance.** Speak to their real issues: economy, family, mental health, leadership. **Research.** Do your homework. If you are doing a play about cultism, talk to people. Don't just guess. **Respect.** Respect the audience's intelligence. Stop with the funny costumes that make us a joke, the off-key singing, and the drama that ends with "and then Jesus came." We can be funny without being foolish. We can be spiritual without being shallow. If we raise the standard, the schools, NGOs, and media houses will invite us. If we don't, we will remain in the corner, singing to ourselves.

The Cost of Mediocrity

Let us tell ourselves the truth. A lot of people see Christian theatre as a joke because we have treated it as a joke. We rehearse once. We use any cloth. We scream to cover lack of technique. We laugh at our own mistakes on stage. Then we wonder why nobody takes us seriously. Colleagues, we play in the theatre. But we must never play with the theatre. The theatre is serious. It shapes culture. It shapes souls. Sloppy craft does not just waste time. It damages the credibility of the Gospel. It tells the world that God is not worth our best. We must repent of mediocrity and embrace discipline as a spiritual act.

Discipleship Through Drama

The process of acting is itself discipleship. Memorization forces the Word into your spirit. Rehearsal builds diligence and patience. Character study builds compassion for people different from you. Teamwork kills pride and selfishness. Receiving correction builds humility. Fasting before a major production builds dependence on God. The stage is a school. It is not just where we perform. It is where we are formed. Many actors have come to Christ through drama ministry because the discipline exposed their heart. Many ministers have grown in wisdom because playing different characters taught them to see life from other angles. God uses the craft to shape the crafter.

Conclusion and Call to Craft

Colleagues, hear me clearly. There is a distinction we must never forget. **Secular acting asks:** How can I get the audience to look at me? **Ministerial acting asks:** How can I use myself so the audience sees the Truth? One seeks applause. The other seeks transformation. One seeks fame. The other seeks faithfulness. Do not settle for mediocre drama. Do not settle for spiritual

laziness. Rehearse with precision. Study your characters deeply. Master voice, body, and text. Read the theories. Practice the craft. And do it all with a heart surrendered to God and devoted to serving your audience.

Final Charge: Priesthood on the Platform

When technique meets the truth of the Gospel, lives are transformed. I have seen hardened men weep. I have seen addicts get delivered. I have seen backsliders return, all because a story was told well and told with the Spirit. The stage is not just a platform. It is a pulpit. It is not just performance. It is priesthood. You are not just an actor. You are a steward, a witness, a voice. May God find us faithful in this art and on this altar. May our lives and our craft point every eye away from us and to Jesus. For to Him belongs all glory, now and forever. Amen.

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DATE: 27TH JUNE, 2026

TIME: 4:30PM - 6:00PM